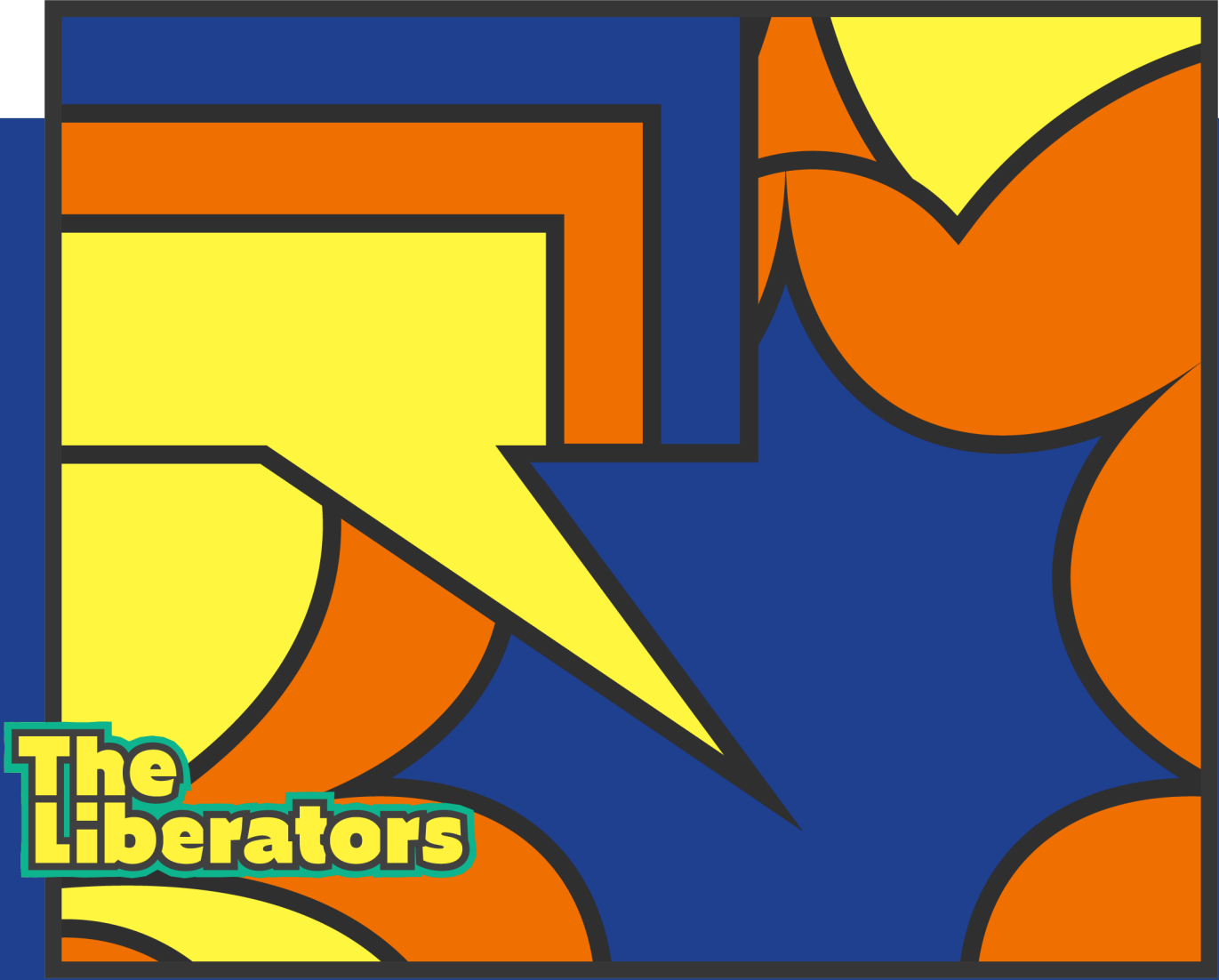


Improve How Your Team Uses The Definition Of Done

A do-it-yourself workshop to revive your Definition of Done and to actually put its rules into practice!

An abstract graphic featuring a dark blue background with large, bold, stylized shapes in orange and yellow. The shapes include a large yellow arrow pointing right, a yellow rectangle, and several orange and yellow curved shapes. The text "The Liberators" is written in a bold, yellow, sans-serif font with a thick black outline and a slight shadow, positioned in the bottom left corner of the graphic.

**The
Liberators**

The Purpose Of This Workshop

Hey there,

The Definition of Done defines what a high-quality Increment looks like for your team. It usually contains criteria such as "The code is covered by unit tests" or "Support documentation is available", or even "The language has been proofread by an editor". The more clear your team is about what quality means to them, the less rework and the more professional your results will be.

Creating and using a Definition of Done is easy and involves three steps:

1. Create the Definition of Done
2. Use the Definition of Done
3. Take the Definition of Done to the next level

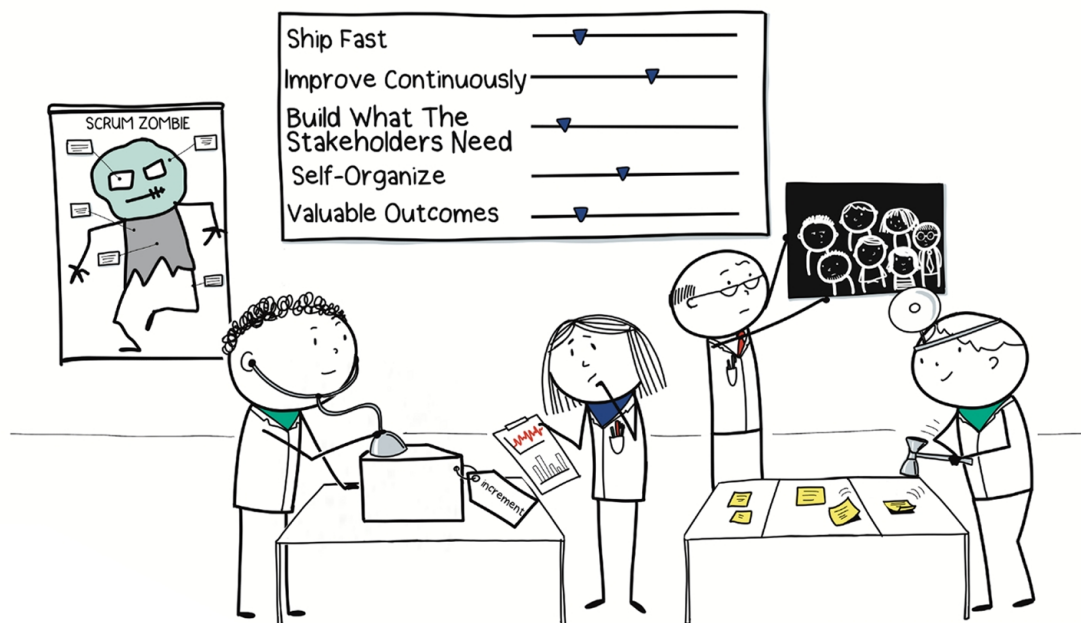
For this do-it-yourself workshop, we assume you already have a Definition of Done. The biggest challenge for your team is to actually use it. Over time, the Definition of Done has become this piece of paper next to the Sprint Backlog that nobody really pays attention to. Product Backlog items are moved to "Done" without checking the Definition of Done. Maybe some items live up to the quality standards, but chances are they don't.

Many Scrum teams don't purposefully ignore the Definition of Done, they often don't know how to apply the rules. Sure, the rule of "all code must be reviewed by another developer" sounds great, but our Sprints are packed with so much work that it feels impossible to do. The purpose of this workshop is to revive your Definition of Done and to actually put its rules into practice!

Let's learn and grow, together!

Barry & Christiaan

The Liberators



Created by Thea Schukken for the Zombie Scrum Survival Guide
by Christiaan Verwijs, Johannes Scharlau & Barry Overeem
zombiescrum.org

Flow



Step 1: Opening

 3 min

Step 2: Clarify The Purpose

  20 min

Step 3: Identify The Rules Of The Definition Of Done

  25 min

Step 4: Determine Whom You Need To Involve

  20 min

Step 5: Consider Your Structure

  20 min

Step 6: Identify Practices To Follow The Definition Of Done

  20 min

Step 7: Decide On Personal Next Steps

  10 min

Step 8: Closing

 2 min

Total duration

 120 min

Difficulty / Effort



Required Skill



If you're new to Liberating Structures, try basic structures to explore the 5 elements of Purpose-to-Practice.

Impact On Survival



Purpose-to-Practice helps to structure ambitious initiatives like developing kick-ass, high-quality products. It makes it more specific and practical, so everyone knows where to start.



How To Prepare

Group Size

This string of Liberating Structures is feasible from 4 participants and onward.

Intended Audience

We designed this workshop for one Scrum team that wants to improve their usage of the Definition of Done. Run this workshop first with the team only, this includes the Scrum Master and Product Owner. Optionally, share the outcome with the stakeholders to gather feedback and make possible improvements.

Virtual Delivery

Liberating Structures work well virtually. Here too, they allow you to unleash and involve everyone. What is exceptionally important, however, is that you have the right tools. Because Liberating Structures are fundamentally about breaking down large-group interactions into smaller groups, you need tools that allow you to create subchannels or breakout rooms easily. [Zoom](#) is ideal for this, but similar features are available in tools like [Teams](#) and [GotoMeeting](#). We also recommend a virtual whiteboard where you can collect shared insights, like [Mural](#), [Miro](#), or [Google Slides](#). Even [Slack](#) can work.

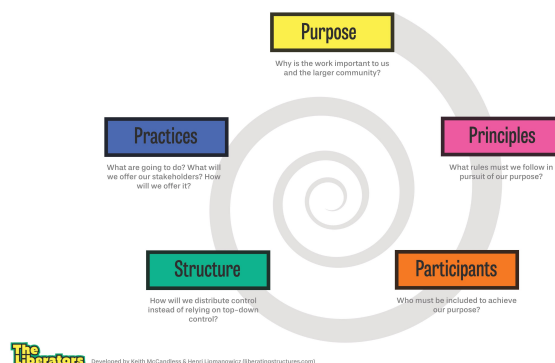
Preparation

- Prepare slides or supporting materials for the various rounds and their invitations.
- Prepare basic slides or a virtual whiteboard to collect your insights. You can also [include this poster](#) about Purpose-to-Practice there.
- An example of a Purpose-to-Practice can be found [here](#). This was created by the Dutch Liberating Structures User Group, and is occasionally updated.

Resources

- Whitepaper: [Scrum: A Framework to Reduce Risk And Deliver Value Sooner](#)
- Blog post: [Why Scrum requires completely "Done" software every Sprint](#)
- Blog post: [Myth: In Scrum, new features are delivered only at the end of the Sprint](#)
- Podcast episode: [So, When Will It Be Done? And How Much Will It Cost?](#)
- Blog post: [Shaping Resilient Initiatives With Purpose-to-Practice](#)
- [Purpose to Practice](#) on the Liberating Structures website

Purpose To Practice



About Done Increments And The Definition Of Done



The Purpose Of Scrum

If you were to capture the purpose of the Scrum framework in a single sentence, it would be to work empirically by delivering a Done Increment at least once every Sprint. This is also why it is so important that Scrum teams spend time clarifying what is involved in creating an increment that is Done. What work is required to do this? Which checks and tests are necessary to conform to our internal quality guidelines? Who needs to be involved in this? This shared understanding is called the **Definition of Done**, and it usually takes the form of a checklist.

The Risk Of Assumptions

The work on the Product Backlog tends to be chock full of assumptions until they are completed and put into the hands of users. For example, "Will implementing this item improve the experience of users?", "Will users understand how it works?", "Does it perform well enough?" Other assumptions will be about the work that needs to be done to implement the item, like "How easy will it be to test and deploy this item?", "What issues will we run into when working on this item?", "How well do we understand what to build?".

Every assumption represents a risk. The risk that you misunderstood what a user asked for and need to rework it. The risk that you run into technical limitations when you start writing the code. The risk is that the feature performs much worse than expected. The risk that writing automated tests turns out to be much harder. Or the risk of spending money and time on a feature that ends up not being used. What these risks all share is that they result in more and unexpected work somewhere down the line. And this kind of "carry-over" work has a tendency to be invisible until it pops up when you least expect it, messing up what you are working on in that Sprint. This is called "Un-done work".

How To Manage Risk

The best way to prevent the risk of un-done work is to make sure that each Sprint results – at least once – in a Done Increment that can be potentially released. That means that the Increment has been fully tested and is working. Texts and visuals are in their final state. Documentation and deployment packages are up-to-date. And performance and security conform to organizational standards. From here, the increment can be released to users with the proverbial press of a button. From this point onward, you know that there will be little to no potential un-done work that can mess up the focus and predictability of future Sprints. More importantly, it allows you to exercise empirical process control by releasing the increment to see if this moves your product closer to its ambitions, rather than assuming that it will.

Creating a Done Increment for every Sprint is certainly challenging. But purposefully so. Because putting this amount of pressure on the system that is creating the product – to do all the work necessary to achieve this – shows clearly where improvements are necessary. Where skills, tools, and technologies are missing. Where bureaucracy is getting in the way. Where impediments need to be removed in order to actually work empirically and reduce the risk of complex work. By keeping a laser focus on delivering a Done Increment at least once every Sprint, the system will start hurting in the right spots and create opportunities for inspection and adaptation.

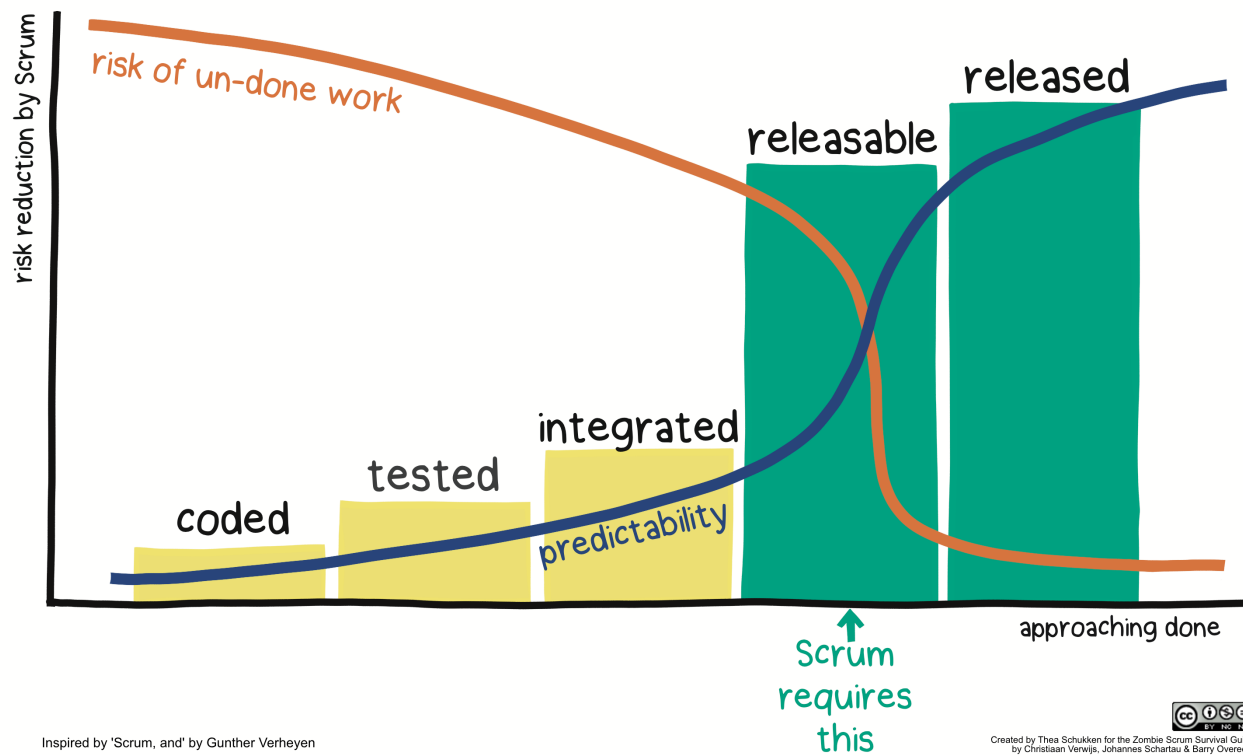
In A Nutshell

So, if you need to explain this to your team, here are the key takeaways you should emphasize:

- The Scrum framework requires a useful, Done Increment at least once every Sprint. Only then can a Scrum team truly validate underlying assumptions with their stakeholders. Each Increment represents a step towards achieving the larger Product Goal;
- The Definition of Done makes explicit what the state of the Increment should be when it meets the quality measures required for the product. The Definition of Done applies to the Increment as a whole and to each Product Backlog item that is a part of that Increment. Work that does not meet the Definition of Done is not considered part of the Increment;



- As the Definition of Done becomes more comprehensive, the chance of problems popping up that require further time from the Scrum team decreases. This improves quality, predictability and lowers risks;
- Scrum teams that are unable to deliver Done Increments every Sprint are unable to truly reduce the risks that are inherent to complex work. Although they may already benefit from the rules of Scrum, they are not doing Scrum yet.
- When teams and organizations focus their efforts on delivering useful Done Increments every Sprint, they will rapidly discover what impedes their Agility. This can range from missing skills, obsolete technologies, dependencies to other organizational impediments;



Step 1: Opening

Start at the scheduled time. People who drop in later can jump in then. We always start our gatherings by simply saying "Hi!", followed by our name. We then explain the purpose and start with the first structure. Superfast!

We've learned that the best way to drain energy is to talk for a long time, to ask everyone to introduce themselves, or to wait for people to drop in.



Step 2: Clarify The Purpose

The Liberating Structure [Purpose-to-Practice](#) (P2P) is a great start for every initiative. For example a team kickoff, a new project, or the start of a new user group. Each of these initiatives will increase their chance of success by having a shared purpose. The first step of P2P is to define this purpose together. From there, P2P covers other essential elements— principles, participants, structure, and practices — that are designed to help achieve that purpose.

The purpose of this do-it-yourself workshop is to revive your Definition of Done and to actually put its rules into practice! But what would success look like? When have we revived our Definition of Done and how would this influence the quality of our product?

In this first step, you'll use the Liberating Structure [1-2-4-ALL](#) to gather everyone's input on these questions. It doesn't have to result in a perfect purpose statement, but it should clarify what the team wants to achieve.

Invitation

"If we aim to fully revive our Definition of Done, what would success look like? How would this influence the quality of our product?"

Steps

1.  Ask the Scrum team to first individually consider the most relevant ideas and thoughts, writing them down for themselves as needed.
2.  Divide your team into pairs and move them into breakouts. There, they quickly share their lists and add or remove ideas.
3.  Create groups of four, preferably by keeping the pairs together and moving them into new breakouts. Ask the groups to share their lists and build on them.
4.  Together, collect all the ideas on a shared workspace and remove duplicates as needed.

Our Findings

- 1-2-4-ALL is purposefully quick. Even though people may individually struggle to generate much, the group as a whole will. You can always do a second 1-2-4-ALL if you need to go deeper.
- Facilitate the silent self-reflection firmly, before the paired conversations, and invite everyone to write down their ideas. This allows participants to focus and make ideas tangible and specific.

Resources

- The [original article](#) for "1-2-4-ALL" from the Liberating Structures website
- Blogpost: [Engage Everyone Simultaneously in Generating Questions, Ideas, and Suggestions with 1-2-4-ALL](#)





Step 3: Identify The Rules Of The Definition Of Done

In the previous step, you've clarified the purpose of the initiative to revive your Definition of Done and to actually put its rules into practice. But what are the rules and principles of the Definition of Done? What rules do we need to respect in order to deliver the desired quality? In this step, you'll help the team to answer these questions.

The Liberating Structure [Min Specs](#) is a great structure for this. It invites people to first think as broadly as possible – encouraging all sorts of creative and outside-of-the-box ideas – and then funnels it back down to what is absolutely essential.

Optionally, considering using the card deck [Definition of Done exercise](#). The blue cards contain potential rules for the Definition of Done and can be used for inspiration.



Invitation

"What are the essential criteria we must follow to deliver a kick-ass, high-quality increment to our stakeholders each Sprint?"

Steps

1. **2 min** Ask everyone to individually and silently generate a list of rules, criteria, and principles.
2. **8 min** Invite people into small groups (3–5) and move them into separate breakouts. Together, they consolidate their lists and expand them to make them as long as possible (Max Specs).
3. **8 min** Bring everyone back to the main channel and explain the next step. Once they're back in their breakouts, ask the groups to test each of the items on their lists against the purpose statement. Let them ask: "Can we still be successful with this Scrum team if we broke this rule?". Each group removes all the items that aren't absolutely essential (Min Specs).
4. **8 min** When everyone is back in the main channel, collect the remaining rules on a shared workspace, removing duplicates and clarifying as needed.

Our Findings

- We often encourage teams to generate more rules for the "Max Specs"–part. This drives more creative and less obvious rules that may end up being super important. At the same time, we always encourage teams to be more minimalistic during the "Min Specs"–round
- It is better to end with two, three, or maybe four clear rules that people will absolutely adhere to than to generate a list of a dozen abstract principles.

Resources

- The [original article](#) for "Min Specs" from the Liberating Structures website
- Blogpost: [Use 'Min Specs' to help groups discover what is absolutely essential](#)



Step 4: Determine Whom You Need To Involve

Now that you've identified the rules of the Definition of Done, it's time to determine whom you need to include in order to achieve your purpose. What stakeholders, customers, users, managers, or other teams need to be involved? The Liberating Structure [1-2-4-ALL](#) is a great way to quickly surface the most important participants to involve, invite, or acknowledge (when they're already present).

If you need to involve many other people and departments, it might indicate that your team has many dependencies. It's important to make this transparent and allow you to work together to reduce it.

Invitation

"Who must be included to achieve our purpose?"

Steps

1. **1 min** Ask the Scrum team to first individually consider the most relevant participants or groups of participants, writing them down for themselves as needed.
2. **2 min** Divide your team into pairs and move them into breakouts. There, they quickly share their lists and add or remove participants.
3. **4 min** Create groups of four, preferably by keeping the pairs together and moving them into new breakouts. Ask the groups to share their lists and build on them.
4. **5 min** Together, collect all the participants on a shared workspace and remove duplicates as needed.

Our Findings

- This second use of 1-2-4-ALL is a good example of the Liberating Structure principle "repetition is also a form of learning". By doing 1-2-4-ALL twice in a row, but with a different question, people start building the skill to run these structures on their own – without facilitation.

Resources

- The [original article](#) for "1-2-4-ALL" from the Liberating Structures website
- Blogpost: [Engage Everyone Simultaneously in Generating Questions, Ideas, and Suggestions with 1-2-4-ALL](#)





Step 5: Consider Your Structure

One of the tenets of Liberating Structures is that control is distributed, rather than in one person or a small group. So, how will you organize yourself as a team, in such a way you can achieve the purpose of developing high-quality products? What tooling are you going to use? Who will be accountable for what? How will you collaborate and frequently synchronize the progress you've made?

Invitation

"How can we organize ourselves in such a way so that we achieve our purpose of developing kick-ass, high-quality products?"

Steps

1. **1 min** Ask people to first individually consider how this Scrum team can organize themselves in order to achieve to purpose.
2. **2 min** Invite people into pairs and move them into breakouts. There, they quickly share their ideas and build on them.
3. **4 min** Invite people into groups of four, preferably by keeping the pairs together and move them into new breakouts. Ask the groups to share their ideas and build on them.
4. **5 min** Together, collect all the participants on a shared workspace and remove duplicates as needed.





Step 6: Identify Practices To Follow The Definition Of Done

Now that you have more clarity on the purpose, the principles, and the structure it is important to consider what it is that you will be doing together; *the practices*. This step is crucial because if your team struggles with using the rules of the Definition of Done, it's often because of missing or unclear practices. The practices describe the behavior of the team in order to apply the rules in principles.

Example 1:

- Principle: items are only done when reviewed by another developer
- Practice: a developer creates a pull request for a change, and another developer reviews the pull-request

Example 2:

- Principle: items related to are checked by key stakeholders
- Practice: we design a standard questionnaire for stakeholders

Example 3:

- Principle: items should have improved code coverage, or it should at least not have been decreased
- Practice: we test code coverage automatically on a build server with [plugin]

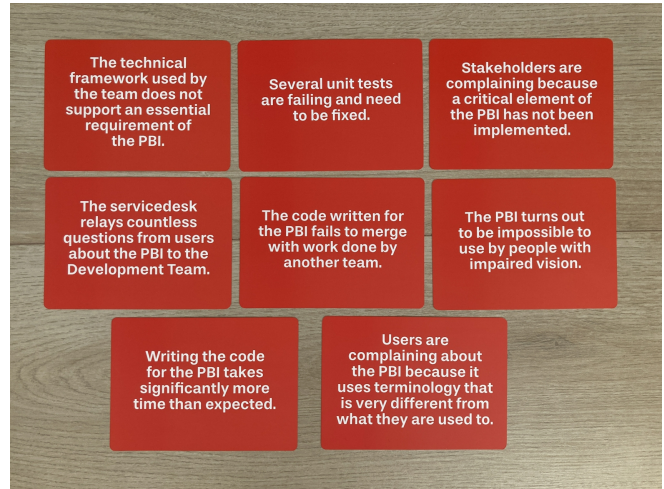
Optionally, consider using the card deck [Definition of Done exercise](#). The red cards contain potential problems that might occur. For the problems that your team recognizes, consider what practices you must use to prevent, or fix them.

Invitation

"What practices do we need to use, and what behavior must we show, in order to successfully use the Definition of Done?"

Steps

1. **1 min** Ask people to first individually come up with ideas and examples.
2. **2 min** Invite people into pairs and move them into breakouts. There, they quickly share their ideas and build on them.
3. **4 min** Invite people into groups of four, preferably by keeping the pairs together and moving them into new breakouts. Ask the groups to share their ideas and build on them.
4. **5 min** Together, collect all the participants on a shared workspace and remove duplicates as needed.



Step 7: Decide On Personal Next Steps

We like to end sessions on a personal note by asking people what it is that they want to contribute to the success of this initiative. No matter how small, if everyone makes one small change, together this generates large change. The Liberating Structure [15% Solutions](#) is super useful for this.

Invitation

"What is your personal 15% Solution to revive our Definition of Done? What is a good next step for you, personally?"

Steps

1. **3 min** Ask everyone to silently generate a list of personal 15% Solutions.
2. **5 min** Form pairs and invite each pair into their own breakouts. In the breakouts, people take turns to share their 15% Solutions. We always encourage listeners to help their partner find a way to guarantee that they will actually do those things (e.g. make it smaller, simpler).
3. **2 min** When everyone is together, ask people to add their 15% Solutions to a shared workspace and briefly mention what they intend to do.

Our Findings

- It is tempting for people to complicate their 15% Solutions, which makes it unlikely they'll actually do them. You can encourage people by asking them "What is the thing you're going to do to work on that [original idea]?"

Resources

- The original article on [15% Solutions](#) on the Liberating Structures website
- Blog post: Trigger BIG change by starting small with ["15% Solutions"](#)



Step 8: Closing

With this workshop, you helped your Scrum team revive their Definition of Done and gave them enough structure and guidance to put its rules into practice!

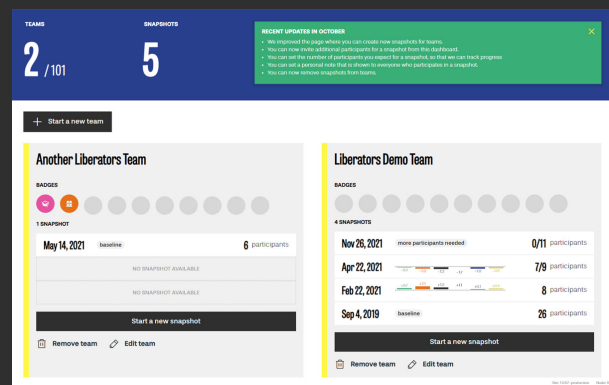
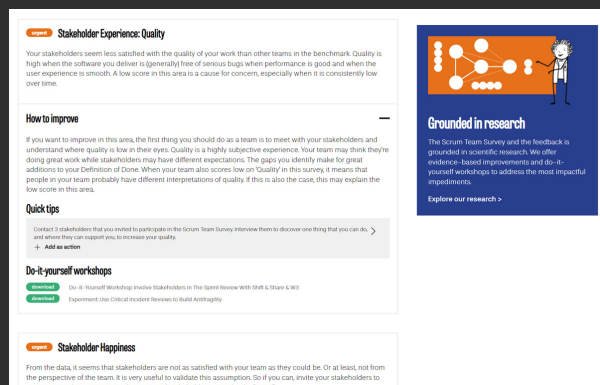
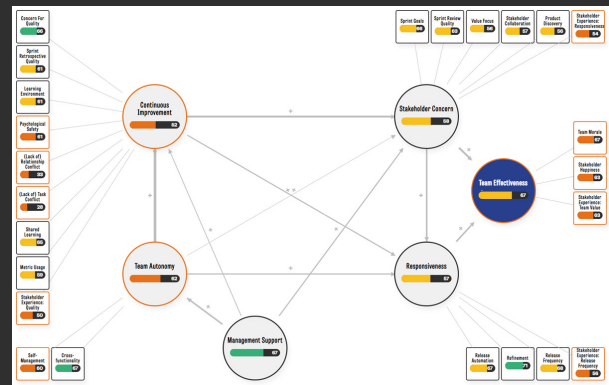
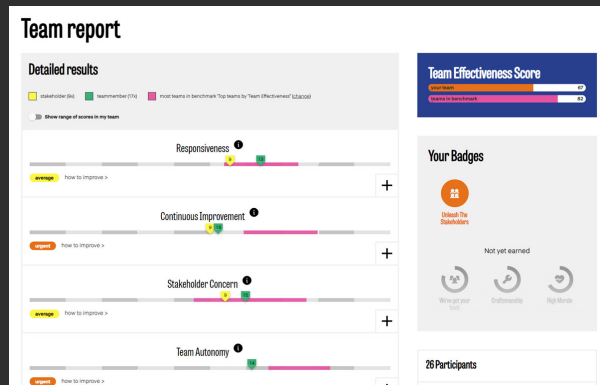
If you've got any questions, comments, or ideas: always feel free to reach out and share them with us.

Let's learn and grow, together!



Make Your Scrum Team More Effective

Want to make your Scrum team more effective? We created the Scrum Team Survey to help. Invite members and stakeholders to a detailed questionnaire and diagnose the results together. You receive tons of actionable feedback based on your results, including dozens of quick tips and useful do-it-yourself workshops. You can use the Scrum Team Survey for free with your team. No account or e-mail address is required. You can also subscribe for more advanced features.



	Essential	Liberator
Invite team members & stakeholders	unlimited	unlimited
Quick Tips for your team per topic	3	unlimited
Recommendations to your team	5	unlimited
Compare your team against different benchmarks		✓
Maintain one or many teams from a single dashboard		✓
Receive our personal guidance on how to get started		✓
See where your team improves over time with Insights		✓
Unlimited data retention		✓
Pricing per team per month	€ 0	€ 15

<https://scrumteamsurvey.org>

info@scrumteamsurvey.org

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